

Mars Cosmetics

Backstory

It started, as many great stories do, with a single stubborn question.

Around 2006, a Delhi-based businessman named Manoj Sethia was moving through India's disorganised offline cosmetics trade, a world of wholesale markets, dusty stockrooms, and erratic supply chains. He was good at it. Business was steady. But something nagged at him every time he walked past a cosmetics counter: why did quality makeup have to be so expensive, or so foreign? Indian women were being forced into two extremes. On one side were premium international brands that many consumers simply couldn't afford. On the other side was an unorganized market filled with low-quality products and inconsistent formulations. The middle ground barely existed. Most beauty companies were either selling aspiration or affordability. Very few were delivering both.

For years, Manoj kept this conviction simmering. He built his offline trading business learning the cosmetics supply chain from the inside out, understanding what manufacturers could deliver, what consumers were actually buying, and where the white space was. Then, around 2014–2015, he made his move.

MARS Cosmetics was launched as an internet-first D2C beauty brand with a simple vision: offer premium-quality makeup at affordable prices for Indian consumers. Operating from a modest facility in Delhi, the brand introduced everyday essentials like lipsticks, foundations, eyeshadows, and blushes, specifically designed for Indian skin tones and weather conditions.

However, the first three years were far from successful. Despite strong product quality and Manoj Sethia's deep understanding of the cosmetics trade, online sales remained stagnant. The products were available, but the brand lacked visibility, differentiation, and a clear identity in an increasingly crowded beauty market dominated by emerging players like Sugar Cosmetics, MyGlamm, and Nykaa.

Recognizing the need for change, Manoj brought in his son, Rishabh Sethia. His assessment was straightforward: the products were good, but the brand positioning was weak and the pricing strategy failed to resonate with the target audience. This realization would eventually become the turning point in MARS's journey.

The Genius Move: *Price Like a Weapon*

Rishabh's great insight wasn't about a new product category or a viral campaign. It was something far more structural and therefore far more durable.

He looked at the Indian D2C beauty landscape and saw a crowded middle: every startup was pricing their products between ₹600 and ₹800 chasing the "premium aspirational" consumer. Legacy brands like Lakme were entrenched at the mass-premium tier. And the absolute budget end was dominated by the unorganised market with unpredictable quality.

There was a **gap**. A massive, underserved gap at the ₹250–₹400 range high enough to signal quality, low enough to be an impulse purchase for middle-class India. Nobody was playing there with genuine quality products.

The Indian beauty and personal care industry is valued at over ₹1 lakh crore and continues to grow rapidly.

Several factors drive this growth:

- Rising disposable income
- Increasing female workforce participation
- Social media influence
- E-commerce penetration
- Tier-2 and Tier-3 city demand

However, one statistic mattered more than all the others.

Nearly 75% of India's cosmetics market was still fragmented and unorganized when MARS was building its foundation

The turning point arrived when Rishabh Sethia joined the business.

Instead of asking:

"How do we beat Sugar?"

He asked:

"Why are we fighting in the same battlefield?"

At the time, most D2C beauty brands priced products between ₹600 and ₹800. Everyone wanted to appear premium. MARS noticed a neglected customer. A consumer who wanted quality but wasn't willing to spend ₹700 on a lipstick. The company strategically positioned itself in the ₹250–₹400 range. This was neither cheap nor premium. It was an affordable aspiration.

This single decision became MARS's strongest competitive advantage.

From Bedroom Brand to *Industry Recognisance*

Unlike many D2C brands, MARS never relied solely on its website. Most startups followed:

Website → Ads → Customer

MARS followed:

Customer → Wherever she shops

The company aggressively expanded through:

- Amazon
- Nykaa
- Flipkart
- Purpille
- General trade stores

Instead of forcing customers to discover MARS, MARS appeared wherever customers already existed.

This dramatically reduced customer acquisition costs and accelerated growth.

The momentum, once it started, compounded quickly. Sales on Nykaa and Amazon began climbing. The product reviews particularly for MARS's liquid lipsticks and sindoor (one of the few categories they manufacture in-house at their **Noida, Uttar Pradesh facility**) were consistent enough to create organic word-of-mouth that money couldn't easily buy.

But the moment MARS truly announced itself to the industry came in **May 2024**. At the **77th Annual Cannes Film Festival**, a 21-year-old self-taught fashion designer from Baghpat, Uttar Pradesh **Nancy Tyagi** was making international headlines. She was one of India's most beloved internet sensations, known for creating breathtaking gowns from scratch. And MARS Cosmetics was her **Official Makeup Partner**.

The Cannes partnership was a masterstroke of cultural timing. Nancy Tyagi wasn't a Bollywood star or a paid celebrity; she was a working-class creator who embodied exactly the kind of aspirational yet accessible story that MARS stood for. Her appearance at Cannes wasn't just a fashion moment; it was a statement: that quality, creativity, and Indian identity belonged on any stage in the world. MARS's branding understood this instinctively.

Also in 2024, the brand received the **Shiprocket Shivir Excellence in Smart Affordables Award** for its 4-in-1 Travel Brush recognition of its product innovation at accessible price points. The same year, MARS cleared a significant commercial milestone: **₹200 crore in revenue as of March 2024**.

By this point, MARS had over **2.5 million customers**, was stocked in over **8,000 general trade stores** through a network of **400+ distributors**, and was live on every major Indian e-commerce platform. The brand that struggled online for three years had become one of the fastest-growing homegrown cosmetics companies in India.

The *Marketing Genius*

Most beauty brands purchase attention.

MARS purchases trust.

Instead of allocating huge budgets to celebrities, MARS focused heavily on:

- Micro influencers
- Nano creators
- Beauty reviewers
- College creators

Approximately 30–35% of influencer spending goes toward smaller creators rather than celebrity endorsements.

Why?

Because consumers trust creators who look like them.

A college student is more influenced by a creator with 20,000 followers than a Bollywood actress promoting lipstick.

This allowed MARS to achieve stronger engagement while spending significantly less than larger competitors.

The Business Model *Others Missed*

Beyond pricing and distribution, several strategic choices set MARS apart from the crowd of Indian D2C beauty brands:

1. Bootstrapped by Design, Not Circumstance. Most D2C beauty brands in India raised VC capital and then faced the pressure to grow at any cost. MARS chose a different path or rather, the path chose it and the result is a business that owns its growth, its profitability, and its direction. No investor demands quarterly hypergrowth. No dilution. No forced pivots.

2. The Hybrid Manufacturing Model. MARS sources broadly third-party manufacturers across India, imports from China, Taiwan, and Germany for components but manufactures select high-value, high-margin products (liquid lipsticks, sindoor) in-house at its Noida facility. This creates cost efficiency at scale while protecting quality on signature SKUs.

3. SKU Depth as a Moat. With 800–1,000 SKUs, MARS offers a product for almost every need and occasion. This breadth is a significant advantage on marketplace platforms where MARS can dominate search results across multiple categories simultaneously. Few bootstrapped brands can maintain this kind of product depth.

4. India-First Formulation. MARS products are explicitly formulated for Indian skin tones and India's humid, hot climate. This isn't just a marketing claim, it's an R&D decision that creates genuine product differentiation against global brands whose formulations were developed for cooler, drier climates.

5. Kiosk Strategy as Brand Experience. Rather than opening full-format stores (capital-intensive), MARS is building a network of kiosks in high-footfall malls combining low capital expenditure with high brand visibility and trial opportunities. The target of 200 kiosks by 2030 would create a nationwide physical brand presence without the overhead of a traditional retail rollout.

The Battlefield: *Who MARS is Fighting*

BRAND	POSITIONING	KEY STRENGTH VS MARS	MARS ADVANTAGE
MARS Cosmetics	Mass-premium, India-first, affordable	—	Price-quality ratio, SKU depth, bootstrapped agility
Lakme (HUL)	Mass-premium, legacy brand	Decades of brand equity, salon network, HUL distribution	More affordable, digitally native, faster to trend
Maybelline (L'Oréal)	Global mass-premium	Global R&D, brand prestige, wide retail	India-specific formulation, lower price, independent distribution
SUGAR Cosmetics	Millennial-premium, D2C, ₹415 Cr revenue	Bold branding, strong retail network, VC-backed	Lower price band, broader SKU range, bootstrapped flexibility
MyGlamm	D2C, celebrity-backed (Good Glamm Group)	Shraddha Kapoor endorsement, content-commerce model	More focused, less brand confusion, stronger product depth
Nykaa Cosmetics	In-house brand of India's largest beauty platform	Nykaa platform distribution advantage, strong online presence	MARS is platform-agnostic; not dependent on any single channel
Pilgrim / MCaffeine	D2C, skincare-led, natural positioning	Clean beauty positioning, younger demographic loyalty	MARS dominates color cosmetics specifically; different category focus

The Next Chapter: *A ₹1,000 Crore Dream*

Rishabh Sethia isn't being coy about what MARS wants to become.

The brand has publicly stated its ambition to reach **₹800 crore to ₹1,000 crore in revenue over the next three years** a 4–5x scale from its current base. This is not a passive aspiration; it comes with a concrete investment and execution roadmap.

In terms of offline expansion, the kiosk strategy is central. MARS plans to open **50 new kiosks in FY2026** alone, bringing the network toward its stated goal of **200 kiosks by 2030**. A **₹15 crore investment** has been committed to this physical expansion phase, alongside investments in brand outlets in modern trade formats like Shoppers Stop and mall concourses.

Beyond color cosmetics MARS's founding category the company is now eyeing **skincare and haircare** as major new verticals. This is a natural extension: a customer who trusts MARS for her lipstick is a warm prospect for a MARS moisturiser or hair serum. The brand is building out **700+ new SKUs** across these adjacent categories, transforming from a makeup brand into a full-spectrum beauty company.

The Next *Billion-Rupee Opportunity*

1. Skincare

The biggest opportunity.

Consumers already trust the brand.

A successful sunscreen or serum line could unlock huge growth.

2. Campus Ambassadors

Nobody owns the college beauty market.

MARS could create:

- Student creators
- Campus beauty clubs
- Ambassador programs

This would generate thousands of micro-influencers.

3. International Expansion

High-potential markets:

- UAE

- Nepal
- Bangladesh
- Southeast Asia

Indian beauty products already have demand there.

4. AI Beauty Try-On

Imagine seeing a lipstick on your face before buying.

This could dramatically improve online conversion rates.